

Coursework Assignment 2025-6

ACF318: Professional Ethics

Department of Accounting and Finance, Lancaster University

Additional Guidance (to be read alongside the module outline)

This coursework assignment asks each student to undertake a detailed ethical review of a single organisation of their own choice. The goal of the review is to provide something that a student might be able to present to an ethically aware investor, new senior employee, or other stakeholder in the business who wants a better understanding of how ethics forms a part of organisational activity, decision making, the social and environment context within which it exists, or any other area where ethics has an impact, or should have an impact.

The report should not be addressed to the organisation, it should not be written as a piece of consulting work, and should not contain recommendations for the company.

Specific requirements:

No two students can select the same organisation unless specific approval has been given by the lecturer – which will only be given if you are intending to work for an organisation that you wish to study (choices must be uploaded to the specific forum thread on Moodle, first person to select an organisation will be the only one allowed to study it).

All work should be the students own work (see module outline for specific explanation of this point, and rules about use of AI), but the use and appropriate citing of multiple other sources of evidence, insight or advice is essential (citations using Harvard referencing style only please, <https://answers.lancaster.ac.uk/display/LLD/Harvard+Referencing>). A good or very good report would most likely cite between 50 and 100 separate sources, in order to show a depth of study and a level of robust evidence to back up the analysis and the claims you ultimately wish to make.

Usually, we expect students to make the piece non-judgemental and ethically balanced, as an independent review and evaluation of the activities and strategies of the firm.

A DIGITAL copy of your review must be uploaded to the specified Moodle space. Note that this is a REPORT and not an essay so the document you load up should look like a professional report and not like an academic essay or literature review of response to exam-type questions.

Guidance on task completion:

This coursework is designed to be progressive, and to allow you to put into practice the work we complete throughout the lectures, tutorials and case study sessions of this module.

Advice on how to succeed with this coursework will be given continuously, throughout the module, and is embedded in all the learning that takes place. You should ensure that you attend all lectures (which are described in your timetable as 'workshops') and make a concerted effort to engage in all group activities.

In previous years students have said that this coursework has been a highlight of their studies, allowing them great freedom, but also placing them under new forms of intellectual pressure. For these reasons you are strongly advised to begin immediately, and not stop working on this, bit by bit, every week until the deadline for submission.

Guidance on developing a high quality report

- Each piece of analysis within your report needs to try to explain something, some aspect of the overall situation you are exploring. In doing this it must draw on multiple sources of data – you cannot make a statement of fact (eg this is a very big company) without it having some evidence to back it up.
- Statements you make need to be specific and related to clear evidence. For example, do not say “this is a global firm” and include no citations – you should say “this firm operates in 87 countries across the Americas, Europe, Africa, Asia and Australasia employing around 120,000 people” and this is then followed by cites to show where your data came from.
- The models we have available to us should be used to help us better understand the situation. You need to know the models very well indeed in order to use them properly. The lecture notes/slides are insufficient – they simply highlight the key places to start looking. The readings on Moodle are critical to allowing you to fully understand, then apply, the models. Further self-study and self-search for additional resources and explanations or examples of how the models are used in practice is recommended.
- Do not try to use too many different theories or models – each one you apply needs to be well utilised, with good data, good analysis, and sensible discussion of what you know once you have applied it to a situation: what do you now understand, or what can you now explain in a more analytical or insightful way? This naturally takes up a lot of space, so expect to use 1-3 models or frameworks, then take care to draw the insights together in a well-argued conclusion.
- In practice this approach means you need lots of sources, ideally many different sources, to support your assignment. Good assignments tend to have between 50 and 100 separate

references in them. These should also be diverse, and not reliant too much on the company's own websites or documents.

- The report needs to look like a report, not an essay. This is important as it allows you to be creative in terms of the use of charts, graphics, and so on without that impacting on word count. It also allows you to emphasise key points, and encourages you to write clearly and develop short, neat sentences. The best way to get examples of report styles is by googling “Think tank” or “London Think Tank” and looking at the reporting styles of these institutions.
- You are strongly advised to read the writing guides posted on Moodle before you write too much, or while you do your editing. In the past, many students have lost marks because of poor English grammar. There are learning services available in LUMS to help you with your writing – these are not only for international students, they are for everyone. But these are not proof reading services that you use at the end of your work, these are learning services that you should be talking to by the 2nd or 3rd week of term, to start sharing your writing with them and getting support to improve.
- There are no specific ways to approach this assignment. The key question to ask yourself when you review your own work is: have I created a clear, believable and thorough piece of work that allows the reader to better understand a complex ethical situation?
- Make a start as soon as you can, but do not feel that you need to start at the beginning. Do a bit of analysis – something that might sit in the middle of your report – then think about what needs to go in front of it or behind it.

These are the headlines for the marking grid we use, and some of the questions we ask ourselves as we look at your work. Note that this is NOT a definitive guide to the marking process, but should give you a clue about what elements need to be included in a good submission:

- **Structure & Presentation**
 - Is the ethical problem and perspective clearly set up in the introduction?
 - What is the quality of visual presentation and overall style of the report?
 - What is the quality of English throughout the report?
 - Is the report well structured, to give a logical flow to the ideas?
- **Sources**
 - How good do the sources look – diverse, well selected, not just reliant on company materials?
 - Have the choices been justified, and judiciously used to construct arguments - are there evidence gaps?
 - If academic references are used, are they appropriate and accurately used?

▪ **Theories**

- Which theories are being used here - is it a good cross section from the course?
- Do they seem like the best choices for the intended analysis?
- How well are they used to study the situation, and go beyond mere description?
- Is data used well in the theories, or are assumptions/unjustified statements made?
- Does the theory require more or different evidence, or does it give a sense of reliability and completeness?

▪ **Argument & Insight**

- Are the outputs from theoretical analysis discussed and conclusions drawn?
- Are these ideas and outputs well combined to build the bigger argument or insight?
- Is the flow of these arguments logical and well-constructed?
- How compelling are the points being made?
- Does the flow of argument and evidence follow appropriately from the initial setup in the intro?
- How original or insightful are the ideas being developed?

▪ **Conclusions and Summary**

- How well is everything brought together in the conclusion?
- Are key points made and presented in a way suitable to the intended audience?
- Do statements follow on from the data/analysis/argument or go beyond them?
- Is there any creativity in the insights being drawn out, do they show original thinking?
- Is the executive summary at the front of the document presented clearly and briefly?
- Does the executive summary reflect – but not exceed – the contents of the main report, highlighting key aspects from the entire document?